

caught in a bind as it rejects a process its own government began. After the 1998 nuclear tests, Vajpayee had offered to sign the Comprehensive Nuclear Test Ban Treaty (CTBT)—provided Pakistan and China also signed it—to convert his public declaration of a “voluntary moratorium” on nuclear testing to a legally binding international obligation. But that was then. Now, he has opposed the Hyde Act on the grounds that it bans further nuclear tests by India. The party sees no contradiction in this. BJP leader Yashwant Sinha says, “That was a different situation. Other nuclear states would also

Congress strategist predicts an unstable Third Front government supported by the Left in case of a mid-term poll.

Despite its reluctance to go to the hustings, BJP is keeping the pressure on the Government and pressing for a vote after the debate on the nuclear deal. “No international treaty is ratified by Parliament and we do not intend to set a precedent,” maintains Congress’s Pranab Mukherjee. As L.K. Advani says, “Though it isn’t clear whether the UPA Government will collapse or survive, one thing is sure: it will not last beyond 2008.” Everyone seems to agree.

by Priya Sahgal

ISHAN TANKHA



SCORING A POINT: BJP's support could have let the deal sail through, but it played the nationalist card

have been bound by the CTBT. But thanks to the Hyde Act, India will lose its option of conducting a test even if another country were to test.”

Some in BJP feel it has lost a historic opportunity to claim credit for its role in piloting the Indo-US goodwill. The Congress supported NDA on the Patents Bill; BJP could have risen above the differences and supported UPA on nuclear policy. But then the Congress would have walked away with all the credit. It was politically expedient to play the nationalist card instead. But at what price? Like the Congress, BJP is in no shape to face the electorate yet. It has just lost Uttar Pradesh and Goa, and is gearing for a tough battle in Gujarat and Karnataka, where the ruling alliance is on the rocks. To add to this, the Shiv Sena-BJP alliance needs ironing out.

The UNPA feels its fortunes may change after a mid-term poll. TDP, AIADMK and AGP can only improve their tally in the Lok Sabha, while SP hopes to gain from what Singh calls a ‘bipolar situation in Uttar Pradesh between SP and BSP. “If UPA wants to thrust polls on the nation, we are ready for it,” says TDP’s Chandrababu Naidu, hoping to regain power. A gloomy

TAPPING THE MUSLIM VOTE

The Muslim vote is a critical factor that determines the stand of many parties on the controversial nuclear deal

The Muslim vote has always been crucial to the ascent to power in India. It is more so in the splintered polity that has led to multi-party coalitions in India. It is estimated that the Muslim vote can alter fortunes in as many as 129 of India’s 542 constituencies. Since the rise of regionalism, the Muslim vote has acquired a higher value, as those propping up governments at the Centre, like the Left at present, depend a great deal on the ‘M factor’ for their political survival. Chandrababu Naidu’s exit from NDA and CPI(M)’s criticism of India’s Iran vote are, in that sense, interpretations of the same fear. And why not? After all, the mega rallies that CPI(M) organised against the vote and against the Danish cartoonist enabled them to add 33 seats, taking their tally to 176

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